nuclear relationship that developed between the United States and the USSR during the Cold War. India and Pakistan "will not make exactly the same mistakes as their superpower predecessors." However, he maintains that "while the differences are clear . . . the significance of these differences is not. . . . In both cases, the parochial interests and routine behaviors of the organizations that manage nuclear weapons limit the stability of nuclear deterrence."[44] Despite their differences, then, optimists and pessimists agree that proliferation's impact on the behavior of new nuclear states has little to do with the specifics of the proliferating states themselves.

As a result, competing arguments must be evaluated from a largely deductive standpoint. However, deductively speaking, optimistic and pessimistic approaches to nuclear weapons proliferation are equally plausible; there is no purely logical reason to believe that either deterrence-based or organizational arguments are more powerful. In order to judge the arguments' relative merits, one must carefully apply them to specific instances of nuclear proliferation and determine how well they explain observed phenomena. Does the behavior of nuclear proliferators in particular cases conform better to the expectations of the optimists or to those of the pessimists?

In the case of South Asia, a few recent works have taken such an approach, combining theoretical analysis with detailed, region-specific empirics. But these works have taken single positions in the proliferation debate; none of them have brought competing views together in a single volume, which would make it easier to compare their similarities and differences, and judge their relative strengths and weaknesses. In the pages that follow, we attempt to do so. Ganguly and Kapur offer opposing theoretical views of nuclear weapons proliferation, divergent descriptions of South Asia's nuclear past and present, and very different predictions regarding the region's nuclear future. In chapter 3, we discuss our opposing theories. Ganguly argues that nuclear weapons have contributed to stability in the region. By stability he means that neither side will now plan on carrying out a full-scale conventional war against the other for fear of nuclear escalation. Indian and Pakistani decision makers comprehend that nuclear weapons constitute a revolutionary